

Vietnamese soil, the gunship was born. The original gunship was nothing more than a DC-3 aircraft with a minigun in the door, but even this was so absurdly effective that the Vietnamese ceased all offensive activities the moment they realised a gunship was in the air.

The concept was later fully fleshed out and the result was the fearsome AC-130J Hercules. A behemoth of a plane that was armed with twin 75mm guns, 30mm minigun and a 105mm canon. Coupled with the ability to loiter for hours on end while providing fire support, the AC-130 Hercules gunship was, and still is, one of the deadliest weapons flying in the air today.

DRONING ON

Drones are considered to be the future of warfare. A remote war, a modern one with no mess, no blood and guts and no PTSD. A pilot sits at home and blows up a dam halfway around the world. Is this the ideal form of warfare? Some believe it is. Aircraft such as the Globalhawk have gained worldwide renown and some level of infamy for their ability to strike targets behind enemy lines with impunity. These aircraft may be pilotless drones, but they still cost more to manufacture than three F-15 aircraft. But the savings in terms of human lives? Priceless.

Drone warfare is still in its nascent stages however and while aircraft like the X-37B do pop up on our geek radars from time to time, they're yet to see mass deployment. For now, push-button warfare is a myth. In the future? Who knows what may be.

NAVAL WARFARE

Of all forms of war, naval warfare is the one that might have changed the most since the end of WWII. Ships of that era were massive gun platforms capable of firing tonnes of projectiles in every salvo. Today, ships are smaller, a fraction of the size they once were (barring the aircraft carriers) but many times as lethal. The primary weapon of choice is now the cruise missile, a guided missile system that's capable of precisely laying waste to targets thousands of kilometres away.

Interestingly, while ships do still carry guns, they're piddly in comparison to the 18-inch calibre behemoths of yore. Even armour has come



The DDG 1000, the stealthiest, most advanced guided missile destroyer in the world

down drastically, with low weight and stealthy profiles being given a much higher priority than armour. This is understandable considering that if a missile does get through a ship's defences, it's curtains for the crew regardless of the armour. That said, the chance of a missile, or even a shell, getting through the formidable missile defence systems at the disposal of most ships today is very slim. Also note that guns on naval ships aren't really dead. A 5-inch Naval gun of today is at least as effective, if not more so, than most WWII era guns. Both in terms of lethality and range.

Consider the 150,000 tonne Nimitz class aircraft carrier for example. Outfitted with about 150 (estimated) RIM-7 Sea Sparrow or RIM-116 RAM type missile defence systems, the carrier is in theory able to defend itself against even the most intense missile barrage. This

is even before we consider the Phalanx CIWS (Close-In Weapon System), an automated defence system that can lay waste to incoming aircraft and missiles with its formidable 20mm canon that can unleash a barrage of lead at 75 rounds per minute.

The advancement in drone technology also means that it won't be long before ships will be outfitted with drone launcher and recovery devices (some of them might already be thus outfitted), giving naval vessels unforeseen flexibility in terms of their scope of operation and mission parameters.

STILL NOT SATIATED?

So far, we've only scratched the outer surface of the myriad military tech available today. We haven't spoken about the advancements in missile technology, tandem warheads, automated targeting systems and more.

There have been major advances in laser technology, rumours of space-based weapons' platforms that are already in orbit and clandestine research into weather control. War is a terrible thing and it allows men to get away with doing terrible things. However, we're not here to judge the morality of war, we're here to acknowledge our appetite for destruction and revel in the destructive potential of our species, morbid as that sounds.

We might be a destructive species, but hopefully we have developed enough sense to limit ourselves to simply flexing our muscles rather than slugging it out. 

DDG 1000 DESTROYER

The most modern warship that we're currently aware of is the DDG 1000 stealth destroyer. A so-called Zumwalt class guided missile destroyer, the ship defends itself via the RIM-162 Advanced Sea Sparrow missiles other CIWS systems and of course, its stealth technology and a myriad of other features that are classified for now. Offensive armament is in the form of 155 guns and Tomahawk missiles. Oh and that 155mm gun, it fires a precision guided shell with an estimated range in excess of 180km. Lethal indeed.